

Video transcript

Social engineering

The internet provides convenient ways to meet people, to shop, and more. Have you considered how much trust it takes to make it all work? Most companies and people have good intentions, but others want to use your goodwill for their own gain.

Social engineering is a manipulation technique that exploits human error or emotion to gain private information, access, or valuables. Malicious actors build these attacks around how people behave and think. They prey on vulnerable victims, both emotionally and technologically. It's easy to fall victim to a social engineering threat, both in person and digitally. Let's highlight a few of the many types of these attacks.

Most people have heard of phishing, one of the top cyberthreats. This is when attackers mask themselves as a trusted or legitimate source and send fraudulent email. Maybe it looks like you got an email from Amazon asking you to update your payment information immediately by clicking on a certain link. However, if you click that link, you'll go to a site that captures your bank information instead. The email wasn't from Amazon, and you were phished.

Another dangerous social engineering threat is the honey trap. This is when someone uses a fake identity to befriend or get romantically involved with someone else to cultivate the victim's trust. When that happens, they coax the victim to give them money or information.

Not all social engineering threats are online. Tailgating is when a malicious actor follows you into a building to gain unauthorized entry, hoping you won't mind if they don't have a pass. When you enter your school or workplace, watch your back. Someone who follows you might plan to carry out a malicious act on the organization's internal network or files.

Shoulder surfing is simply watching when someone is typing a password or listening to sensitive information someone is discussing on the phone. Even something basic like watching who's sitting nearby is important. Someone you don't know could watch you type sensitive information and take note of it.

Since social engineering attackers prey on human emotion and trust, think carefully about the people and technology you interact with, and how to determine what you can trust. Easier said than done, right?

These attacks can be hard to spot. But never fear! You can learn simple habits to help you avoid attackers while still enjoying the best of what technology offers.